
Hidden voices in the archive: African agency and missionary networks in Gold Coast

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Abstract

Nineteenth-century missionary archives from the Gold Coast (present-day Ghana) can be reread not only as instruments of evangelization but as evidence of dense, collaborative infrastructures of African knowledge work. Between the 1820s and the 1880s, the Basel Mission and the Church Missionary Society developed presses, schools, and letter-writing circuits that produced reports, grammars, translations, and periodicals. While scholarship has emphasized the role of missions in colonial epistemologies (Comaroff and Comaroff, 1991), the archive also preserves traces of African intermediaries (teachers, catechists, translators, printers) whose labor and expertise shaped what could be written, printed, circulated, and remembered (Debrunner, 1967).

This research asks: how can sources produced under asymmetrical power relations be methodologically reassembled to foreground indigenous agency and translocal intellectual networks in nineteenth-century Ghana? Methodologically, the study combines prosopographical network analysis with close reading and archival ethnography. It draws on missionary correspondence from the Basel Mission Archives' Ghana holdings (1861-1895), Carl Christian Reindorf's *History of the Gold Coast and Asante* (1895) and archival documentation of the multilingual *Christian Messenger* (1883-1912). These materials are contextualized through critical engagement with archival organization and provenance (Jenkins, 2003) and through attention to practices of translation, recordkeeping, and collaborative authorship that complicate single-author missionary narratives (Peterson, 2004). By tracing named actors across letters, institutional records, and print artifacts, the analysis reconstructs overlapping networks linking mission stations, African towns, and wider Atlantic-facing circuits.

The research reveals three forms of African intellectual authority that missionaries could not replicate. First, catechists exercised gatekeeping power over baptismal admission, evaluating candidates' spiritual readiness before European missionaries acted. Second, African intermediaries conducted autonomous pastoral circuits between stations, providing baptismal instruction and literacy teaching without direct supervision. Missionary correspondence explicitly acknowledges these competency gaps, noting that certain pastoral work required knowledge "which a foreigner cannot do". Third, mission-trained Africans leveraged their literacy to occupy strategic political positions as secretaries and advisors to indigenous rulers, mediating between missionary, colonial, and African authority structures.

Reindorf's scholarly monograph, published through Basel Mission press and distributed internationally, exemplifies African intellectual production that transcended intermediary roles (Reindorf, 1895). His preface advocates explicitly for African historical authorship, arguing

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that histories "written by a foreigner would most probably not be correct" (Reindorf, 1895). The extensive corpus of African-authored articles in the trilingual Christian Messenger, preserved in mission archives yet largely unanalyzed, represents a significant gap in Gold Coast intellectual history.

Reframing missionary archives through a network lens reveals hybrid intellectual spaces and forms of mediated communication that cannot be reduced to unidirectional "colonial influence". The approach demonstrates that fragmentary, biased documentation can be reassembled as a resource for writing histories of knowledge circulation from the margins. African actors engaged in strategic negotiation, operating simultaneously within multiple religious and political systems while accumulating institutional authority over time. This reframing challenges binary frameworks positioning missionary work as either colonial imposition or indigenous resistance, foregrounding instead African intellectual labor as constitutive of missionary knowledge production in nineteenth-century West Africa.

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African Intellectual Networks in Basel Mission Gold Coast, 1861-1895

Edge color = decade documented

1860s (n=6)
1870s (n=7)
1880s (n=20)
1890s (n=3)

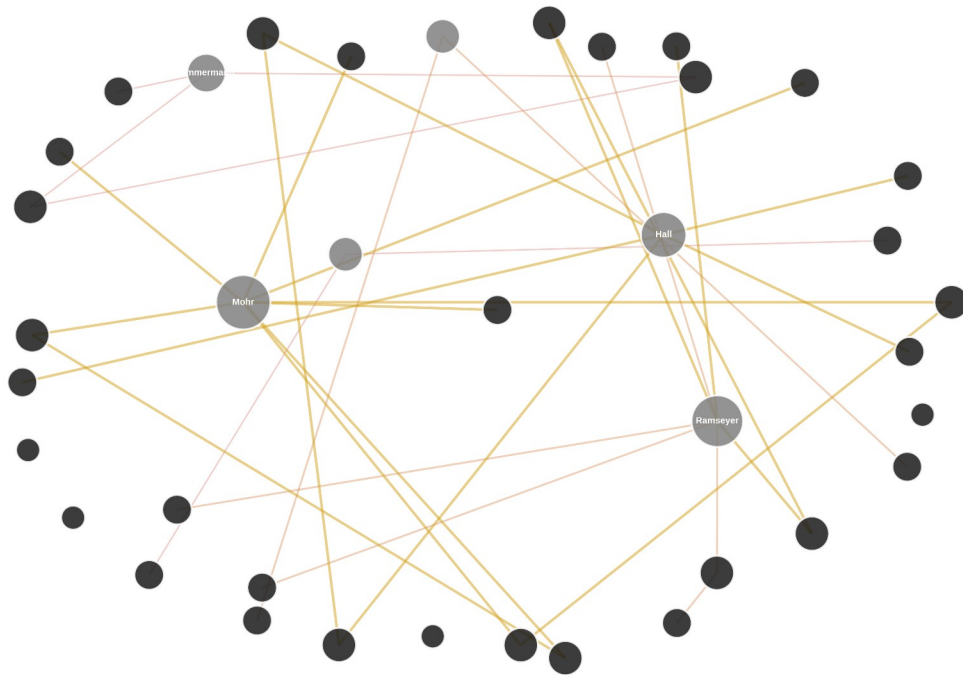


Figure 1 - Temporal Network Evolution. Temporal evolution of African intellectual networks in Basel Mission, Gold Coast (1861-1895). Edge colors indicate decade: red (1860s), orange (1870s), gold (1880s), green (1890s). Dark nodes = African intermediaries; gray nodes = European missionaries. Node size = degree centrality. The 1880s concentration (56% of connections) reveals temporal unevenness in archival documentation. Source: Basel Mission Archives, D-01 series.